

of God, there was no deal or give and take. There was nothing that I demanded of Musharraf. The only thing I wanted was a level playing field in Pakistan. I wanted the judiciary, that was told to go out of office, to be restored. What I wanted was constitutional amendments to be lifted. Of course, these things haven't been done. I am back in Pakistan and can see there is no change on the ground.

Q. You are not satisfied by Musharraf doffing his uniform and possibly lifting the Emergency.

A. No. Whatever he may do—doff his uniform, lift the Emergency, withdraw the Provisional Constitutional Order or PCO but as long as he doesn't reinstate the judiciary to the position it was on November 3, when he imposed Martial Law or Emergency, the problem will remain unresolved.

Q. Why is that?

A. The earlier judiciary had everybody's confidence. This judiciary has been installed by Mr Musharraf. It has given out a verdict in favour of Mr Musharraf in a matter of days. The earlier judiciary went by the book and the Constitution. Everybody would have accepted their decision even if it favoured Mr Musharraf.

Q. You have filed your nomination papers for the elections. Would you be contesting?

A. Though I have filed the nomination papers, under these circumstances one is skeptical about the transparency of the elections. We have very great apprehensions about fairness. These conditions are not conducive to free and fair elections.

Q. Do you think the Election Commission favours Musharraf?

A. The election commissioner, is of course, a handpicked man of Mr Musharraf. He owes his allegiance to him and not to the state. And therefore nobody has any confidence in him. It is very important that there is a neutral election commissioner and a neutral caretaker government.

Q. Are you planning to form an alliance with Benazir Bhutto?

A. We are not thinking of any electoral alliance with Benazir Bhutto but

we would certainly like to sit and discuss possibilities of putting forward joint demands to ensure free and fair elections. The key issue of course is that the judiciary must be reinstated. All other things are secondary.

Q. So have you spoken to her about it?

A. Yes we spoke to her. I told her we must emphasise the restoration of the judiciary. She said

“ Amendments made to the Constitution by Musharraf must be thrown out. ”

confine itself to the role that the Constitution describes. The army should play its role within the four walls of what is defined for it under the Constitution.

Q. Are you okay with General Kayani's appointment as chief of army staff?

A. He is the senior-most general and a man who perhaps deserved that position. I have personally nothing against him.

Q. You said you would not serve under President Musharraf. What happens if you become prime minister in January?

A. I will be honoured if the people of Pakistan consider me worthy of becoming prime minister of this country again. But then I will only accept this office with the intention of restoring the Constitution to its original 1973 position. This is the Constitution which the people of Pakistan support and I would throw out the amendments to the Constitution which have been passed during military regimes.

Q. So in short you won't serve under Musharraf?

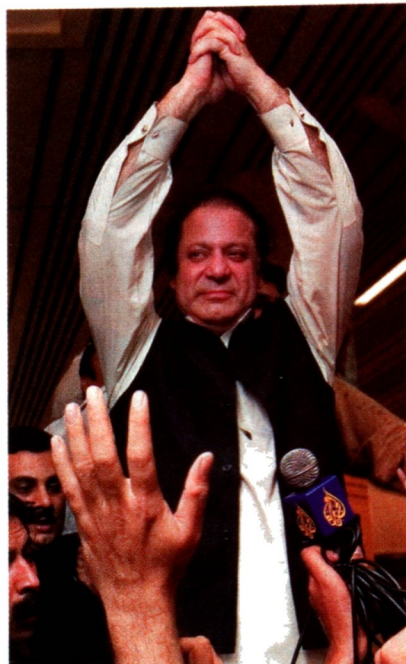
A. Obviously! We must not lose sight of the fact that we have a Parliamentary democracy in Pakistan. But today it's just in name. Actually it is the President of Pakistan who is calling all the shots and is all powerful today. The prime minister is totally subservient to the President.

Q. Do you have any ill-feelings towards Musharraf?

A. I have no ill feelings. I think one must rise above such animosity. I am only interested in ensuring that my country moves forward on the road to democracy. My country must now say goodbye to dictatorship and military rule. These interventions played havoc in the country. Key institutions are in a shambles—the judiciary is under house arrest—the freedom of the press taken away from the government.

Q. Should India play a role?

A. India should wait and see and move when we have democracy back in Pakistan. It will be better that democracy talks to democracy rather than to dictatorship.



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yes she would and subsequently she said we must talk about the independence of the judiciary. So I told her we have been talking about the independence of the judiciary for the last 60 years but now what is more relevant after the events of November 3 is the restoration of the judiciary.

Q. What's your election slogan?

A. We want undiluted democracy in the country, the judiciary must function independently, the press must function freely,

Parliament must be sovereign and the Constitution should be supreme.

Q. What role should the army play?

A. The army should

“ India should wait and see. Democracy should talk only to democracy. ”